

SENATE JOINT RESOLUTION 984

By Seal

A RESOLUTION to honor and commend Jerry Kirk on his forty years of distinguished service to Tennessee cooperative communications.

WHEREAS, it is fitting that the members of the General Assembly should recognize those citizens who, through professional excellence and a lifetime of service, have strengthened the institutions that support the people and communities of this State; and

WHEREAS, Jerry Kirk is one such individual, whose distinguished career in cooperative communications has spanned more than four decades and whose work has helped inform, educate, and connect cooperative members and rural communities across Tennessee; and

WHEREAS, in 1973, Mr. Kirk became editor of *The Tennessee Cooperator*, the award-winning membership publication of Tennessee Farmers Cooperative, where his thoughtful leadership and commitment to telling the story of Tennessee agriculture and rural life helped shape one of the most respected cooperative publications in the region; and

WHEREAS, Mr. Kirk later served as editor of *The Tennessee Magazine*, the member publication of the State's electric cooperatives, broadening the reach of cooperative communications and helping share the stories of locally owned utilities and the communities they serve across Tennessee; and

WHEREAS, returning to *The Tennessee Cooperator* in 1990, Mr. Kirk continued his exemplary service until his official retirement in April 2001, leaving behind a legacy of professionalism, integrity, and dedication to the cooperative mission; and

WHEREAS, following his retirement, Mr. Kirk remained actively engaged in cooperative leadership, serving two terms as Executive Secretary of the Tennessee Council of Cooperatives and continuing to contribute as a writer, including through his longtime column "As I Was

Saying," while also assisting with editorial work for both *The Tennessee Cooperator* and *The Tennessee Magazine*; and

WHEREAS, in recognition of his outstanding contributions, Mr. Kirk was presented the prestigious James B. Walker Cooperative Spirit Award in 2012, the highest honor bestowed by Tennessee Farmers Cooperative upon an individual whose service has had a positive and enduring impact on Tennessee agriculture, farmers, and the cooperative system; and

WHEREAS, the Tennessee Council of Cooperatives further recognized Mr. Kirk in 2014 during its Young Leaders Conference for his many years of dedicated support of rural cooperatives and his lasting service to the citizens of this State; and

WHEREAS, throughout his life and career, Mr. Kirk has been supported by his wife, Jane Kirk, and has inspired a continuing legacy of cooperative storytelling through his son, Chris Kirk, who now serves as editor of *The Tennessee Magazine*, reflecting the enduring influence of Mr. Kirk's commitment to service and excellence; and

WHEREAS, a native of Hawkins County and a proud Tennessean, Mr. Kirk is known not only for his professional achievements but also for his warm personality, including his enthusiasm as a master player of Wheel of Fortune, his appreciation for *The Andy Griffith Show*, and his steadfast loyalty as a fan of the University of Tennessee Volunteers; now, therefore,

BE IT RESOLVED BY THE SENATE OF THE ONE HUNDRED FOURTEENTH GENERAL ASSEMBLY OF THE STATE OF TENNESSEE, THE HOUSE OF REPRESENTATIVES CONCURRING, that we honor and commend Jerry Kirk for his exceptional leadership in cooperative communications and extend our sincere appreciation for his many years of devoted service to the cooperatives, the agricultural community, and the citizens of the State of Tennessee.

BE IT FURTHER RESOLVED, that an appropriate copy of this resolution be prepared for presentation with this final clause omitted from such copy and upon proper request made to

the appropriate clerk, the language appearing immediately following the State seal appear without House or Senate designation.